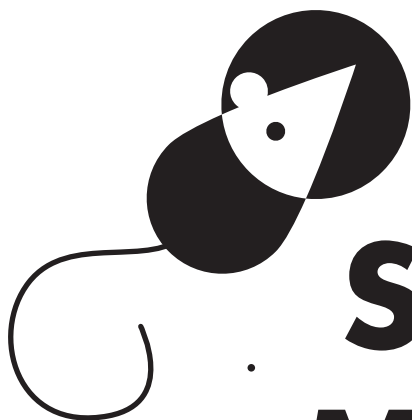
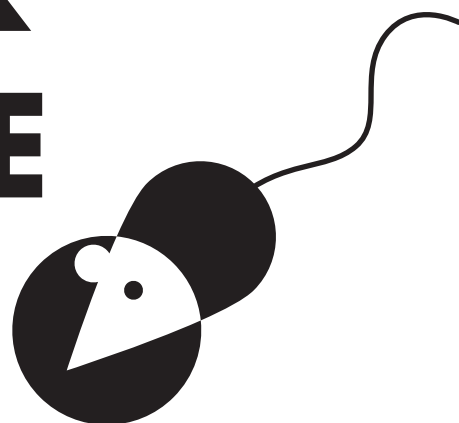




SPACE MOUSE



UNDER WATER MOUSE



WRITTEN & DIRECTED BY
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Spotlight on a CREW MEMBER in a CCT vest, who mimes throughout the following introduction. The style is as if an airline safety video were being written for space travel. There is a glorious march under the announcement. The ANNOUNCER speaks in a chipper newsreel tone. The CREW MEMBER mimes the announcement.

ANNOUNCER (V/O):

Ladies and gentlemen, boys and girls: welcome to Space Mouse/Underwater Mouse. Please take a moment to review this safety briefing, even if you are a frequent audience member with us. At this time we ask you to switch off any mobile phones or other electronic devices, as these may interfere with your enjoyment of the show. We also remind you that there is to be no photography or recording of any part of the performance. You are welcome to meet the performers after the show and take as many photographs as you like. The main exit is located at the rear. If you require a "break from proceedings", please ask one of our staff to show you where to go. Here at The Malthouse, we can proudly state that our theatre has withstood all recent events bravely, thanks to the latest in very expensive steel reinforcement technology, but in the event of further catastrophe, please follow the instructions of our brave and fully-trained volunteers.

Thank you for your attention. Please sit back and enjoy... Space Mouse/Underwater Mouse!

Black.

An underwater house, lit in soft bluish-green light. A "HOME SWEET HOME" tapestry hangs crooked on one wall. Through the window, we can see fish swim lazily past tall yellow coral and dancing seaweed. There is a faint bubbling sound under this scene.

There is a large, comfortable chair in one corner, and a small coffee table, on which sits a large book, a plate of crumbs, and a photograph of two mice. One of the mice in the photo is UNDERWATER MOUSE. The other corner of the room contains a kitchen bench with an electric jug and a few teacups, as well as a transistor radio. An apron hangs from a hook on the wall.

UNDERWATER MOUSE enters from another room. She looks around at the mess and shakes her head. She fills the jug at the sink and turns it on, then, putting on her apron, she begins to tidy up.

Straightening the tapestry takes several attempts. Other tidying activities will depend on the set. Perhaps the audience will suggest chores if prompted.

The house tidy, UNDERWATER MOUSE can relax. She has, of course, timed everything perfectly, and a noise from the jug signals that the tea is ready to be made. She fills a teacup with water, dangles a teabag in it, and turns on the radio as she starts to cross to her chair.

The first music from the radio is immediately distasteful. Returning to the radio, she flicks through the stations until she finds some agreeable light jazz. Smiling, she walks across the room to the armchair, picks up the book, and

sits down. The radio station immediately changes, causing her to nearly spill her tea all over the book.

She jumps up, puts the book and teacup back down on the table, walks across the room to the radio, changes back to the jazz, walks back, picks up the book and the tea, sits down, and the station changes.

Repeat, vary tempo. Attempt to "sneak up" on the chair. Attempt to sit down while reaching for the radio. Etc.

Eventually she gives up, and sits down with the tea and the book while the radio plays Scandinavian death metal. Something is uncomfortable under her, and she puts the tea and the book down to rummage in the cushions of the armchair until she finds the remote control. She flicks back to the jazz, puts the remote in the pocket of her apron, and sips her tea.

She picks up the book and opens it to the first page. The audience helps her read.

AUDIENCE: A is for APPLE.

There is a little victory noise. She turns to the next page.

AUDIENCE: B is for BALL.

Victory noise. She turns the page again.

Lights go red. Horror music. She throws the book across the room in terror. Shaking, she takes a long sip of tea and a few deep breaths until she's calmed down. She retrieves the book, and starts again. A is for apple. B is for ball. C is for... Can she do it?

Will she do it? She screws her eyes shut and slowly turns the page...

Nope. She slams the book shut and begins sealing her house against imagined feline incursions. She closes the curtains, checks the pressure seal on the airlock, then slides to the floor and sits, shaking, blocking the door with her body. In the stillness, she notices the horror music is still playing. Still in her almost foetal position, she slowly pulls the remote from her apron and changes the station back to light jazz.

She has almost recovered, when there is a knock at the door. She leaps up and across the room, hiding behind the chair. Nothing happens.

Then, after an uncomfortable pause, a postcard slides under the door.

UNDERWATER MOUSE gingerly picks up the postcard and holds it up.

She watches through the window as a seahorse in a postman's uniform goes past.

The photograph on the postcard is a beautiful nebula against a backdrop of bright stars; a bold, industrial typeface reads "GREETINGS FROM SPACE!" Everything about the postcard is crisp and futuristic.

UNDERWATER MOUSE bends her head to read the card. There is a brassy, anthemic fanfare, and she leaps back. She tries again, with the same result. She steels herself, and reads the card, fanfare and all. A bright military march plays under the following:

SPACE MOUSE (V/O):

My dear cousin,

Hello from the infinite, untrammelled reaches of the vasty beyond! Ah, space! There's so much to see and do up here. New worlds to explore, new galaxies to chart, important science to... science. But I do miss you, cousin, and I've got some vacation time owing, so I wanted to let you know I'll be splashing down in your area. That's right, I'm coming to visit, so get that little bluish-green dot of yours ready and I'll see you soon.

Over and out,
Space Mouse

*UNDERWATER MOUSE looks up, worried.
She looks down at the card again.*

SPACE MOUSE (V/O:

That's right, I'm coming to visit...

UNDERWATER MOUSE looks around at the state of her house, panics, and begins tidying the house again. This should exactly match the previous sequence of chores, but at double speed. She is just washing and drying her empty teacup when the doorbell rings.

UNDERWATER MOUSE carefully depressurises the seals on the outer door and opens it.

SPACE MOUSE stands in the entrance, wearing a space suit, and dripping wet.

UNDERWATER MOUSE dashes off and returns with a towel.

SPACE MOUSE dries herself off distractedly, throws the towel on the floor, and strides into the room, removing her helmet and looking around her. It is clearly not as awesome as she'd been expecting.

UNDERWATER MOUSE rushes around after

her, picking up the towel and using it to wipe spots on the floor where SPACE MOUSE's suit continues to drip. She takes the helmet, places it carefully by the door, and pours SPACE MOUSE a cup of tea. SPACE MOUSE declines, pulling a sealed pouch marked "SPACE TEA" from a pocket and sucking it through a straw. UNDERWATER MOUSE takes the tea away and returns with a biscuit tin; again, SPACE MOUSE declines, pulling another pouch labelled "SPACE BISCUITS" from a pocket, and sucking that through a straw too.

UNDERWATER MOUSE puts some biscuits on a plate and comes back with the biscuits and the cup of tea. Finding SPACE MOUSE in her chair, she sits on the floor and munches a biscuit slowly.

There is a long, uncomfortable silence.

The two mice occasionally look up at each other as if they're about to start a conversation, then realise they have nothing to say. Otherwise, they drink their tea and eat their biscuits in silence. SPACE MOUSE folds up the pouches carefully and replaces them in her pockets.

More awkward silence.

SPACE MOUSE gets up and wanders around the room, looking at the various appointments.

She turns on the radio. Light jazz begins to play.

SPACE MOUSE frowns and changes the station to something more upbeat.

UNDERWATER MOUSE pulls the remote from her pocket and changes it back, then puts the remote back in her pocket, all without SPACE MOUSE

noticing.

SPACE MOUSE looks confused, and changes the station again.

UNDERWATER MOUSE changes it back.

SPACE MOUSE shrugs, turns off the radio, and walks over to the coffee table.

SPACE MOUSE picks up the book.

UNDERWATER MOUSE looks mildly worried. For a moment she might reach out and stop SPACE MOUSE, but she doesn't.

SPACE MOUSE opens the book to the first page.

AUDIENCE: A is for APPLE.

SPACE MOUSE is hooked by this incredible literature. She turns the page.

AUDIENCE: B is for BALL.

Thrilled by this new development, SPACE MOUSE is just about to turn the page when UNDERWATER MOUSE snatches the book away and places it on the table, before she can realise what a terrible invasion of her guest's personal space this is. She retreats to her place on the floor.

The book sits between them on the table.

There is a pause.

Both mice launch themselves at the book. SPACE MOUSE is slightly quicker. She begins at the beginning again.

AUDIENCE: A is for APPLE.

B is for BALL.

SPACE MOUSE turns the page with great anticipation.

Red lights. Horror music.

In desperation, UNDERWATER MOUSE throws herself across the room, on top of her cousin and the terrible book. SPACE MOUSE laughs and shrugs her aside. She turns the page, revealing that...

AUDIENCE: C is for CAT.

SPACE MOUSE is silent for a moment, then bursts into wild, helpless laughter. She rolls round the floor, tears streaming from her eyes, while UNDERWATER MOUSE sits awkwardly across the room, looking down at her paws. UNDERWATER MOUSE's expression goes from shame to an embarrassed smile to mild offense to consternation. She picks up the book and throws it at her cousin.

SPACE MOUSE attempts to apologise.

UNDERWATER MOUSE is resolute.

SPACE MOUSE remembers something. She pulls an envelope from her pocket and offers it to UNDERWATER MOUSE, who takes it after a bit of insistence. She opens the envelope.

It is a shiny golden ticket to Space.

UNDERWATER MOUSE doesn't get it.

SPACE MOUSE opens the book at a new page.

AUDIENCE: S is for SPACE.

UNDERWATER MOUSE is still confused.

SPACE MOUSE turns back a page.

AUDIENCE: R is for ROCKET.

*UNDERWATER MOUSE finally gets it.
She makes a "who, me?" gesture. Nod.
"Up there?" Nod.*

*This is too much. She tries to give
it back. No you, no you, etc, until
finally she accepts.*

*UNDERWATER MOUSE is very excited,
and begins immediately to pack,
pulling a large suitcase from behind
the armchair.*

*She isn't sure what she might need,
so she holds various things up to
the audience for them to decide.*

*After some false starts, she finally
finishes packing and they're ready
to go. But.*

*UNDERWATER MOUSE looks down at her
clothes.*

*She looks at SPACE MOUSE's fancy
space suit and helmet.*

*She looks at her own dress, apron,
and slippers.*

She has an idea.

*She opens a wardrobe, revealing a
full old-fashioned diving suit.*

SPACE MOUSE gives her a thumbs-up.

Snap to black.

Empty stage, stick puppets.

*Tight spot on a small underwater
house.*

*A submarine manoeuvres out the
bottom of the house and makes its
way to the surface.*

*A hatch opens. Two figures make
their way ashore to a waiting rocket
ship.*

MISSION CONTROL (V/O):

5... 4... 3... 2... 1... IGNITION!

The rocket ship blasts off. The water/land drops away and the rocket continues upwards.

Strauss's Blue Danube Waltz begins to play as a space station appears and the rocket orients itself for docking.

As the music crescendoes, the rocket and the space station dock and the lights go black.

Sounds of beeping electronic maintenance systems, softly hissing life support.

Harsh white light.

We are on SPACE MOUSE's orbital home. It is laid out quite similarly to UNDERWATER MOUSE's home, but with more technological analogues of the various elements. The tapestry on the wall says "HOME AWESOME HOME". There are no chairs or tables. Everything is tied or latched or bolted so it doesn't float away. Through one window the earth is visible as a distant blue-green orb, spinning lazily against a backdrop of stars.

The two MICE enter, walking in exaggerated spaceman slow motion. UNDERWATER MOUSE is wearing her apron over her diving suit. SPACE MOUSE is carrying the book.

SPACE MOUSE gestures for UNDERWATER MOUSE to take off her helmet.

She shakes her head.

SPACE MOUSE takes her own helmet off and breathes exaggeratedly.

UNDERWATER MOUSE is still reluctant.

SPACE MOUSE reaches over and gently removes the helmet.

UNDERWATER MOUSE is holding her breath.

SPACE MOUSE demonstrates breathing again.

UNDERWATER MOUSE shakes her head.

SPACE MOUSE tickles her.

She laughs, breathes, then realises breathing is okay, and does it some more.

UNDERWATER MOUSE looks around in awe at the interior of the station.

She looks through the window at the earth.

She turns back to SPACE MOUSE, who nods proudly.

She continues exploring the station.

SPACE MOUSE goes to a panel on the wall and brings back more of the pouches.

UNDERWATER MOUSE tries each in sequence, sucking the contents through a straw.

First is okay. Second is very tasty! Third is disgusting.

She lifts it up to examine it, turning it around so that we can see it is labelled "SPACE BROCCOLI". She spits and sputters.

SPACE MOUSE takes the pouches away.

UNDERWATER MOUSE examines a button on a panel on the wall, and gives it a tentative push.

There is an "access denied" noise.

She pushes it again. Same noise.

She pushes it a third time. Loud klaxons, red flashing lights.

SPACE MOUSE hurries over, struggling in the low gravity. She deactivates the alarm, chiding UNDERWATER MOUSE, then pushes an adjacent button. SPACE MOUSE's music begins to play.

SPACE MOUSE goes back to clearing away the rubbish.

UNDERWATER MOUSE surreptitiously takes the remote out of her apron pocket and changes the music.

She looks around for something to do. She finds a ringbinder that she hopes will be a storybook, but it turns out to be a technical manual full of diagrams and formulae.

SPACE MOUSE takes the manual off her and studies it, making thoughtful noises and adjusting settings on various controls around the room.

UNDERWATER MOUSE is bored.

She starts to examine a small screen set into one wall. At first it is inert.

Then it begins to emit regular blips.

She jumps back.

She uses her remote to turn off the music.

Blips continue.

She moves over to SPACE MOUSE, who is still engrossed in the manual. She taps her on the shoulder and points at the display.

SPACE MOUSE looks at her accusingly. UNDERWATER MOUSE denies responsibility.

SPACE MOUSE flips through the manual. The blips become louder and more frequent. UNDERWATER MOUSE begins to panic.

SPACE MOUSE finds something in the manual and is about to try it on the console when the blips stop.

Dead silence.

The mice share a relieved hug.

COMPUTER (V/O): INTRUDER. ALERT.

UNDERWATER MOUSE is terrified. SPACE MOUSE thumps the console with a fist.

Lights go red.

COMPUTER (V/O): INTRUDER. ALERT.

Now SPACE MOUSE is worried. The two mice clutch each other in fright.

Silence.

A soft scratching noise.

CAT: Meow.

UNDERWATER MOUSE squeaks.

SPACE MOUSE shushes her.

CAT: Meow.

The scratching is louder. A huge ginger tail dangles down from the air ducts, swishing hypnotically.

CAT: Growl.

The mice are frozen.

UNDERWATER MOUSE slowly pulls the remote from her apron. SPACE MOUSE

is horrified, but UNDERWATER MOUSE has an idea.

She points the remote at the stereo and presses a button.

Lullabye music.

CAT: Purr.

The mice look up at the cat tail.

UNDERWATER MOUSE gestures for the book, opens it to a picture of a bedraggled-looking cat with a broken umbrella and an expression of purest misery.

AUDIENCE: W is for WET.

SPACE MOUSE gets it. She pulls down the "HOME AWESOME HOME" tapestry and hands it to UNDERWATER MOUSE, revealing a sign marked "ESCAPE POD" pointing at a nearby door. They creep over to it in ultra-slow motion.

SPACE MOUSE opens the door and gestures for her cousin to get in. She punches a few buttons on a panel and squeezes into the pod, closing the door.

CAT: [stops purring]

COMPUTER (V/O): SELF-DESTRUCT SEQUENCE ACTIVATED.

CAT: ??!

COMPUTER (V/O): TEN. NINE. EIGHT. SEVEN.

CAT: !!!

Black.

Empty stage, stick puppets.

COMPUTER (V/O): SIX. FIVE.

A tiny escape capsule jets away from the space station.

COMPUTER (V/O): FOUR. THREE. TWO. ONE.

There is a massive explosion.

*A huge, orange-striped spaceship
limps away from the wreckage.*

Black.

Back underwater.

*The mice enter from the sub hatch,
breathless.*

*They remove their helmets, take a
moment to reassure themselves that
they're both okay, and let out a
nervous sigh.*

*There is a catastrophic splash that
rocks the station, flickering the
lights.*

*The mice look at each other in
astonishment.*

A sonar ping.

SPACE MOUSE looks around.

*UNDERWATER MOUSE calmly clears the
coffee table and flips it up on its
end, revealing a sonar screen.*

*There is an icon of a cat in one
quadrant.*

Sonar ping continues.

*She opens a biscuit tin, removes two
keys on lanyards, and hands one to
SPACE MOUSE.*

*They insert their keys into holes on
opposite sides of the set and turn
them.*

Lights go red.

Stirring Soviet music.

RUSSIAN COMPUTER (V/O):

All hands, battle stations.

A torpedo launch console appears. UNDERWATER MOUSE flips up the safety catch and poises her paw above the launch button, motioning to SPACE MOUSE to keep an eye on the sonar console.

SPACE MOUSE is nervous. She pulls a pouch of Space Broccoli from a pocket, takes a large sip, and offers it to UNDERWATER MOUSE, who examines it, thinks for a moment, and then opens a hatch and deposits the pouch inside.

RUSSIAN COMPUTER (V/O):

Payload accepted. Broccoli torpedo armed.

The pings get closer. Now? Not yet. Now? Not yet. Now? Now.

UNDERWATER MOUSE pushes the button.

RUSSIAN COMPUTER (V/O):

Torpedo away.

There is a whooshing noise. SPACE MOUSE is glued to the sonar.

There is a massive explosion and a loud yowling.

More flickering lights and unsteady shaking.

RUSSIAN COMPUTER (V/O):

Direct hit.

The mice dance for joy.

The red lights stop.

UNDERWATER MOUSE switches the music with her remote. Calmly and unhurriedly, she goes around the

room returning it to normal.

SPACE MOUSE is very surprised.

UNDERWATER MOUSE offers her a cup of tea.

SPACE MOUSE gladly accepts.

UNDERWATER MOUSE produces the "HOME AWESOME HOME" tapestry from her apron and hangs it over her own.

They hug.

UNDERWATER MOUSE holds up the book, open to...

E is for END.